

Ararat Gocmen

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary: labor, finance, immigration, entrepreneurship

Secondary: applied, inequality, history

DOCTORAL STUDIES

University College London (UCL) – MRes, MPhil, and PhD in Economics

2027 (expected)

Dissertation: “Essays in Labor and Finance”

Dissertation committee and references:

Christian Dustmann
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Assistant Professor of Finance
Imperial College London
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PRIOR EDUCATION

Queen Mary University of London & University College London (jointly awarded)

2021

MA in History of Political Thought and Intellectual History, distinction

Dissertation: “The Politics of National Difference in Postwar Germany: The Case of Armenian Migrants from Turkey”

University College London

2020

MSc in Economics, distinction

Dissertation: “The Effect of Immigration along the Distribution of Wages: Evidence from Germany during the 2000s”

Princeton University

2017

AB in History, Certificate in European Cultural Studies, *summa cum laude*

Dissertation: “The Age of Extremes in Colonial Context: The Mass Politics of Left and Right in Algiers, 1935-1939”

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Citizenship: United States of America

Languages: English, Armenian, Turkish (native); French, Italian (intermediate); German (beginner)

Skills: Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, SQL

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

ROCKWOOL Foundation Berlin (RFBerlin) – Research Fellow

2026-present

Centre for Research and Analysis of Migration (CReAM) – Research Officer

2020-present

BlackRock Solutions Portfolio Analytics Group – Analyst

2017-2019

Predata – Analyst Intern

2016

European Roma Rights Centre – Legal Intern

2015

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

ECON0121 – Economic History: BSc, Professor Ramin Nassehi	2024-2026
ECON0062 – Topics in Labor Economics: MSc, Professor Christian Dustmann	2023-2024
ECON0050 – Economics of the Public Sector: BSc, Professors Silvia Dal Bianco and Lucas Conwell	2022-2023

AWARDS, GRANTS, HONORS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Best Paper Award in Labor and Public Economics at the Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China	2026
UCL Stone Centre PhD Scholarship	2025
Peggy and Richard Musgrave Prize for the best paper presented at the IIPF Annual Congress	2025
Mercatus Center Adam Smith Fellowship	2024
UCL Stone Centre External Research Support Grant (£50,000)	2023
UCL Faculty of Social and Historical Sciences Dean's List during the MRes in Economics	2022
UCL Department of Economics MSc Prize for the strongest record in department work	2020
UCL Department of Economics Outstanding Dissertation Prize during the MSc in Economics	2020
UCL Faculty of Social and Historical Sciences Dean's List during the MSc in Economics	2020
Marshall Scholarship	2019
Phi Beta Kappa Society	2017
Gamma Kappa Alpha National Italian Honor Society	2017
Princeton Department of History Laurence Hutton Prize for the strongest record in department work	2017
Princeton Department of History Walter Phelps Hall Prize for the best thesis on European history	2017
Princeton Department of French & Italian André Maman Prize for an outstanding thesis on France	2017
Princeton Department of History Lawrence Stone and Shelby Cullom Davis Prize for an outstanding record	2016
Princeton Shapiro Prize for Academic Excellence	2015

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

2026: LSE and CenTax Workshop on Capital Gains Taxation, NHH Department of Business and Management Science and NoCeT Faculty Seminar, RFBerlin-CReAM Summer Workshop, UCL SPP Migration Cluster and ETH Immigration Policy Lab Workshop on Immigration and Political Behavior, Armenian Economic Association Annual Meeting, CSEF-CEPR Conference on Labor and Finance, Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China, World Inequality Conference, Migration and Organizations Conference, UCL Centre for Finance Research Half Day, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2025: Fall Labor and Finance Group Conference, CEPR Paris Symposium, UCL Applied Microeconomics PhD Research Day, NBER Public Economics Program Fall Meeting, Northern Finance Association Annual Meeting, RFBerlin-CReAM Summer Workshop, European Economic Association Annual Congress, NBER Summer Institute Household Finance, Eleventh Conference of the Society for the Study of Economic Inequality, Armenian Economic Association Annual Meeting, IEB and EU Tax Observatory Workshop on the Economics of Taxation, European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting, Lake District Workshop in Corporate Finance, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2024: Asian and Australasian Society of Labor Economics Conference, Madrid Public Economics Workshop, RFBerlin-CReAM Summer Workshop

INVITED PROGRAMS

MIT Stone Centre visit	2026
UBC Stone Centre visit	2026
NBER Entrepreneurship Research Boot Camp	2025
UC Berkeley Stone Center Summer Institute	2023

WORKING PAPERS

“Private Capital Markets and Inequality” – Under Review ([SSRN](#), [CEPR](#), [RFBerlin](#), [VoxEU](#))
with Clara Martínez-Toledano (Imperial) and Vrinda Mittal (UNC-Chapel Hill)

This paper examines how expanding private capital markets contribute to rising economic inequalities in the U.S. We show that the share of early-stage financing raised from U.S. high-net-worth individuals (HNWIs) tripled from 2004 to 2022. Exploiting the expansion of the qualified small business stock (QSBS) long-term capital gains tax exclusion, we find that HNWIs' investments made startups 5.6% more likely to stay private. Counterfactual simulations reveal that HNWIs' excess returns on early-stage investments explain 26% of the growth in the top 0.5% wealth share over 2010-2022. Finally, investor entry increased incumbents' returns and encouraged further investments, generating a self-reinforcing feedback loop between private capital market growth and inequality.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"Immigration and Firm Investment" – Job Market Paper

Firms can finance wages from revenues but may require external financing for lumpy capital expenditures. Constraints on credit supply may therefore lead firms to reduce their capital-labor ratios in response to immigration-induced labor supply shocks, with costly implications for their incumbent workers' earnings. In this paper, I investigate the role of credit as a mediator of the effects of immigration on firms' balance sheets and payrolls. I first introduce credit supply into existing models of the labor market effects of immigration, predicting that initially more indebted firms face external financing premia which limit their investment sensitivity to labor supply shocks. These credit constraints are most costly for incumbent workers at capital-intensive firms, where capital investment is most needed in response to an increase in labor supply. I then test these predictions in the context of Germany, where a large immigration shock during the 2010s followed a sharp contraction in credit supply during the global financial crisis. Exploiting variation across local labor markets in earlier immigrants' settlement patterns and across firms in their initial credit constraints, I find that immigration led to a decline in the aggregate capital-labor ratio. This was driven by sharp declines for the initially most indebted firms, whose incumbent workers suffered lower earnings as a result. Thus, firms' access to credit proves to be crucial in determining the labor market effects of immigration, implying a potential role for macroeconomic policy in facilitating how the labor market absorbs immigration shocks.

"Immigration and Labor Market Tightness" – Presented at [Sixth World Labor Conference](#)
with Thomas Cornelissen (Essex), Christian Dustmann (UCL, and Uta Schönberg (HKU)

This paper examines how the effects of immigration on native workers' employment and wages depend on initial labor market tightness. We first predict, based on a search-and-matching model, that the effect of immigration on native employment is less negative in an initially tighter labor market, while its effect on native wages is more negative. We then test these predictions in the context of Germany during the 2010s, when every annual inflow of immigrants entered in tighter conditions than the previous year's. Comparing the initially slackest and tightest local labor markets, we find that initial tightness attenuated immigration's negative employment effects but amplified its negative wage effects, with these heterogeneities sharper for the lower-wage natives more exposed to competition from immigrants.

PREDOCTORAL RESEARCH

"Workers' Demonstrations and Liberals' Condemnations: The Italian Liberal Press's Coverage of General Strikes, Factory Occupations, and Workers' Self-Defense Groups during the Rise of Fascism, 1919-1922." *Chicago Journal of History*, [Issue 6](#), Spring 2016, pp. 29-43.

This paper documents the evolution of the Italian liberal press's coverage of workers' demonstrations from 1919 to 1922. I show that, in response to the persistence of these demonstrations during this period, Italian liberals became increasingly sympathetic to the growing fascist movement in Italy. I analyze articles from the Italian newspapers *La Stampa* and *L'Illustrazione italiana*, treating their coverage of general strikes, factory occupations, and workers' self-defense groups as indicative of liberals' reactions to workers' demonstrations. By tracking changes in the liberal press in this way, I illustrate how working-class radicalism inadvertently contributed to the rise of fascism in Italy.

"Before Class Struggle: Inequality in European Political and Economic Thought, 1516-1848."

This collection of articles analyzes key contributions to the history of political and economic thought on inequality in the three-plus centuries before Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels' publication of *The Communist Manifesto*. The four essays focus on the writings of Thomas More, William Cavendish II, John Locke, Charles-Louis de Secondat Baron de la Brède et de Montesquieu, and Jean-Charles-Léonard Simonde de Sismondi.

“Otto Bauer’s National-Evolutionary Politics: Cultural Nationalism as Socialist Strategy in Hapsburg Austria.”

This article analyzes the Austrian social democrat Otto Bauer’s theories of how to politically organize the multinational working classes of Hapsburg Austria before the First World War. It was presented at the Twelfth Annual London Graduate Conference in the History of Political Thought in 2021.

“Reinterpreting the Volcker Disinflation: The FOMC’s Anti-Inflationary Resolve (or Lack Thereof?), 1979-1980.”

This article narrates the debates that took place between U.S. monetary policymakers at the meetings of the Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) during the first year of Paul Volcker’s chairmanship of the Federal Reserve from August 1979 to July 1980. I argue that this first year of the Volcker disinflation, often recounted by historians as the later abandonment of an initial anti-inflationary resolve, never featured such resolve in the first place. Rather, some of the FOMC members that originally supported Volcker’s nonborrowed reserves targeting regime did so in the hopes that it would lead to loosening of monetary policy, in contrast to Volcker’s own preferred tightening.